

Learn all the Tenses in English

Your companion guide to the complete
English tenses course!

**From the past simple to
advanced contractions
and everything in
between!**



LEARN ALL THE TENSES IN ENGLISH: COMPLETE COURSE

Welcome to your guide on English tenses! If you've ever felt lost in the maze of present, past and future or felt like completely giving up on perfect and continuous forms, you're in the right place. This comprehensive guide is your map to confidently using the tenses!

Whether you're a beginner just starting out, an intermediate learner looking to level up or an advanced student aiming for absolute precision, this guide has something for you.

Feeling comfortable using the English tenses goes beyond passing tests. This ebook will help you connect the dots and make using these tenses come more naturally. I want you to be able to make plans and connect with people across the globe and this guide will help.

By the time you finish this massive ebook, you'll be navigating English tenses much more easily than you ever have!

 Table of Contents

Please look over the Table of Contents to familiarise yourself with today's lesson. You can also jump to any section you'd like to review.

Content	Pages
The Perfect Tenses	3-14
The Present Perfect vs The Present Perfect Continuous	15-19
'Stop' Using the Future Tense	20-26
5 Tenses = 90% of English	27-33
All 16 Tenses Explained	34-49
-ED pronunciation	50-52
USED TO / USE TO / BE USED TO / GET USED TO / WOULD DO	53-56
HAVE BEEN / HAS BEEN / HAD BEEN	57-73
JUST / ALREADY / STILL / YET	74-77
Advanced (C1 Level) Grammar	78-88
How to pronounce the contractions in English	89-95

The Perfect Tenses

In this lesson, I will explain some of the important uses of the perfect tenses. We'll look at the past, present and future perfect tenses in a way that's easy to grasp. You'll learn to confidently talk about experiences, ongoing situations and actions that lead to later consequences. With practical examples, you'll see how these tenses work in real life so that you can start using them with ease.

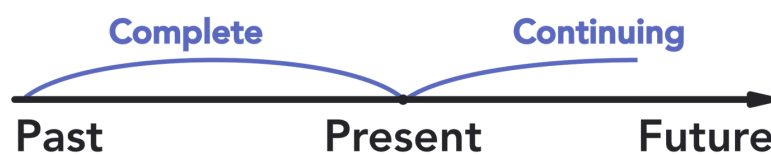
Aspects vs Tenses

I don't normally talk about **tense** versus **aspect** in my lessons, but I think it's important and useful to mention today.

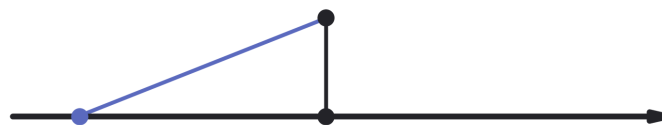
We only have two tenses in English:

present		past	
I go .	She goes .	I went .	She went .

Aspects add information about the way we view a verb. For example, an aspect can show whether an action is complete or continuing.



When we use the **perfect aspect**, we look back from a certain point in time to another point in time. I'm going to explain more about this and give you lots of examples.



I'm going to refer to these aspects as the **perfect 'tenses'** from now on because I think that's the name most of you are familiar with.

Present Perfect Simplesubject + **have/has** + **past participle**I **have been** to London.**negative:**

Add 'not' after 'have' or 'has'.

She **has not been** to London.**questions:**

Invert the subject and 'have' or 'has'.

Have you **been** to London?**Past Perfect Simple**subject + **had** + **past participle**I **had been** to London before moving to Paris.**negative:**

Add 'not' after 'had'.

She **had not been** to London before
that day.**questions:**

Invert the subject and 'had'.

Had you **been** to London before
moving to Paris?**Future Perfect Simple**subject + **will have** + **past participle**I **will have been** to London by next year.**negative:**

Add 'not' after 'will'.

I **will not have been** to London by next
year.**questions:**

Invert the subject and 'will'.

Will you **have been** to London by next
year?

In speech and informal writing, we commonly use contractions

'Have' is often contracted to 've,' and 'has' is often contracted to 's'.

- have → **'ve** = I **'ve** been to London.
- has → **'s** = He **'s** been to London.

In negative sentences, we usually contract 'have not' to **'haven't'** and 'has not' to **'hasn't'**.

- have not → **haven't** = You **haven't** been to London.
- has not → **hasn't** = She **hasn't** been to London.

'Had' is often contracted to **'d**

- had → **'d** = He **'d** been to London.

In negative sentences, 'had not' is often contracted to **'hadn't'**.

- had not → **hadn't** = We **hadn't** been to London.

'Will' is often contracted to **'ll**

- will → **'ll** = They **'ll** have been to London.

And 'will not' is usually contracted to **'won't'**.

- will not → **won't** = I **won't** have been to London.

Lucy's Tip!

Notice the pronunciation of **'have'** /əv/ when used in fast speech -

- They'll have /ðeɪl əv/ been to London.



How to use the perfect tenses

In very general terms, we use the **present perfect simple** to look back from the present time. We use the **past perfect simple** to look back from a point in the past. And we use the **future perfect simple** to look back from a point in the future.

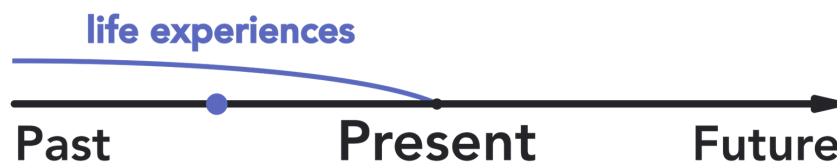
Let's talk about the 3 key uses.

● Life Experiences

The Present Perfect Simple

First, we don't say exactly when these life events happened when we use a perfect tense.

We use the **present perfect simple** to talk about life experiences up to now. The experiences happened in the past, but we are looking at them from the present.



- I **have been** to New York.

That means that at some point in my life up to now, I went to New York. You don't know when exactly, but you know it was before the present time and that this event is completed.

The **present perfect simple** is often used to express actions that have been repeated up to the present, for example -

- I **have been** to New York three times.

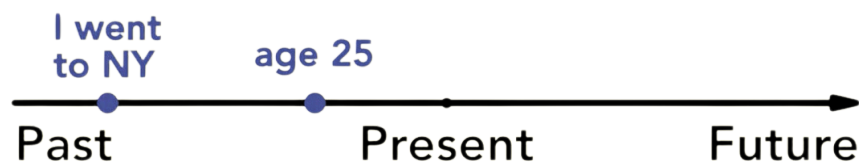
We can also use the negative construction that we saw earlier to talk about life experiences.

- I **haven't been** to New York.

The Past Perfect Simple

We can use the **past perfect simple** to talk about life experiences that happened before a point in the past. Here's an example.

- I **had been** to New York by the time I was 25.



In this example, the point we are looking back from is age 25. I was 25 in the past. And the sentence tells you that before I was 25, I went to New York.

The Future Perfect Simple

We use the **future perfect simple** to talk about life experiences that will be complete by a specific point in the future. Here's the same example again:

- I **will have been** to New York by the time I am 35.



Age 35 is in the future. This sentence tells us that before I am 35, I will visit New York. You don't know when, but the action of visiting New York will happen before I'm 35.

● Unfinished States and Actions

The next use I want to talk about is for **unfinished states and actions**. We can use the perfect tenses to talk about states and actions that begin before a point in time and continue up to that point. This usage often tells us **the duration of the action up to a certain point**.



We can sometimes use the perfect simple or perfect continuous tenses when talking about how long something lasts.

The Present Perfect Simple

We use the **present perfect simple** to talk about states or actions that began in the past and continue to the present. We don't know if they will continue in the future.

Here's an example:

- I **have lived** in Manchester for 5 years.



I started living in Manchester 5 years ago, and I live there now.

If we want to talk about how long something lasts in the present perfect simple, we can use time expressions like '**for**' (a duration) and '**since**' (a point in time).

- **For** is used when we want to give a length of time an action has been happening. This can be a specific or non-specific time.
 - I **have lived** here **for** a long time. (unspecified time)
- **Since** is used to indicate the starting point of the action or situation.
 - She **has lived** here **since** 2015.

I also said we can use the present perfect continuous to talk about the duration of an activity.

The Present Perfect Continuous

When we want to highlight how long an action has been happening up to the present moment, we use the **present perfect continuous**. This tense is particularly useful when the exact starting time is not known or is not important, but the focus is on the ongoing nature of the activity. Here's an example:

- I **have been studying** French for three years.

The emphasis is on the duration of studying French, which continues up to now.

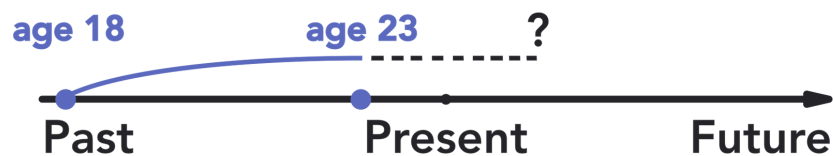
Like the present perfect simple, we can use time expressions such as '**for**' and '**since**'.

- They **have been working** here **for** over a decade.
- I **haven't been eating** out **since** the start of the year.

The Past Perfect Simple

We use the **past perfect simple** to talk about states or actions that began in the past and continued to a later point in the past.

- I **had lived** in Manchester for 5 years by the time I was 23.

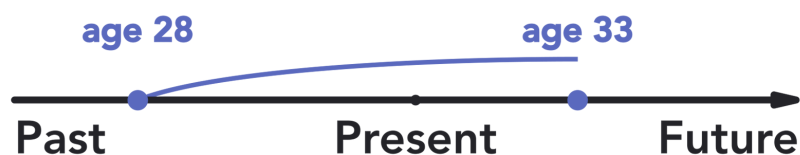


I started living in Manchester when I was 18, and I still lived there when I was 23, five years later. You don't know if I continued living there after that.

The Future Perfect Simple

We use the **future perfect simple** to talk about states and actions that will continue to a point in the future.

- I **will have lived** in Manchester for 5 years by the time I am 33.



In this sentence, the starting point for living in Manchester is age 28, which is in the past. Five years later, I will be 33 and still living in Manchester.

● Consequences

I'm calling the final use '**consequences**'. We can use the perfect simple tenses to talk about **things that happened before a point in time but are relevant at that point**. It's like talking about the consequences of an action or event.

The Present Perfect Simple

We use the **present perfect simple** to talk about an event that happened in the past but is important in the present. Here's an example:

- I've **been** out every night this week so I'm really tired today. (past action with present consequence)

I was out every night up to now and I am tired now.

The Past Perfect Simple

We use the past perfect simple to talk about an event that happened in the past that was important at a later time in the past.

- I'd **been** out every night that week so I was really tired. (past action with past consequence)

I went out every night of a week in the past and the next day, I was tired. Both of those events are in the past.

The Future Perfect Simple

We use the **future perfect simple** to talk about something that will happen before a point in the future that will be relevant at a later time.

- I **will have been** out every night that week so I will be really tired. (future action with likely future consequence)

I will go out every night for a week in the future and then I will be tired.



Additional Practice Sentences

Life Experiences		
Present Perfect Simple	Past Perfect Simple	Future Perfect Simple
We have already seen them live in concert.	He' d never seen snow until he went to Canada.	We will have moved to a new house by June.
They have written three novels already.	They had already ordered when I arrived.	By next year, I will have completed my degree.
I have tried sushi but only once!	By the age of 55, she had climbed the highest mountains in Europe.	My parents will have celebrated their tenth anniversary by May.

Unfinished States and Actions		
Present Perfect Simple	Past Perfect Simple	Future Perfect Simple
Carmine has been a teacher for ten years.	I had been a vegetarian for five years before I went vegan.	I' ll have completed my marathon training by April.
We' ve known each other since childhood.	Bisa hadn't studied French before moving to France.	We will have known each other for twenty years by next month.
I have lived in this town all my life.	Before she retired, she' d worked there for twenty years.	They will have renovated their kitchen by summer.



Consequences		
Present Perfect Simple	Past Perfect Simple	Future Perfect Simple
She hasn't slept well so she's very tired.	They had left by the time we arrived so we didn't see them.	By tomorrow, I will have finished the report so I'll be free to help you.
He has eaten too much so he feels sick.	We had spent all our money so we couldn't go on holiday.	They will have moved out so we'll need to find new tenants.
Frankie and Esther have finished the project so we can relax now.	She had forgotten her umbrella so she got soaked.	She will have saved enough by next year so she will get a new car.



Activity

Choose the correct answer for each question.

- 1) By the time you arrive, we _____ (finish) the project.
 - a. have finished
 - b. will have finished
 - c. had finished
- 2) How do we form a negative sentence in the present perfect simple?
 - a. Subject + have/has + not + past participle
 - b. Subject + had + not + past participle
 - c. Subject + will + not have + past participle
- 3) When do we use the past perfect simple tense?
 - a. To talk about experiences up to the present
 - b. To describe actions that had happened before another action in the past
 - c. To predict actions that will be finished in the future
- 4) Before the pandemic, I _____ (never/think) about remote work as a permanent option.
 - a. have never thought
 - b. had never thought
 - c. will have never thought
- 5) He _____ (not/complete) his homework yet.
 - a. hasn't completed
 - b. hadn't completed
 - c. won't had completed
- 6) I can't believe she _____ (never/to visit) Paris before now.
 - a. will have never visited
 - b. hadn't never visited
 - c. has never visited
- 7) The future perfect simple is used to talk about actions complete before a current moment.
 - a. true
 - b. false
- 8) What is the form of a positive sentence in the Past Perfect Simple?
 - a. subject + had + past participle
 - b. subject + will had + past participle
 - c. subject + have/has + past participle

Answers:

a (8) b (7) c (6) d (5) e (4) f (3) g (2) h (1)



PRESENT PERFECT VS PRESENT PERFECT CONTINUOUS

The present perfect and present perfect continuous tenses can be tricky. They're both used for actions that started in the past and continue to the present. Sometimes, they mean the same thing, but often, there are subtle differences. This lesson will help you understand when to use each tense and how they change the meaning of what you're saying. Let's explore these tenses together to improve your English grammar skills!

INTRODUCTION

We use the present perfect and the present perfect continuous for finished and unfinished actions.

	present perfect	present perfect cont.
positive	have/has + past participle I have worked	have/has + been + verb-ing I have been working
negative	have/has + not + past participle I have not worked	have/has + not + been + verb-ing I have not (haven't) been working
question	have/has + subject + past participle? Have I worked?	have/has + subject + been + verb-ing? Have I been working?

It is important to note that we cannot use the present perfect continuous with stative verbs

Example:

- I've **known** her for years.
- **NOT**: I've **been knowing** her for years.
- I've **been** here for a while.
- **NOT**: I've **been being** here for a while.



We can use them both to talk about unfinished actions that started in the past and are still true in the present. We often use them both with 'since' and 'for'.

Sometimes, especially with the verbs '**live**', '**study**' and '**work**', there isn't a difference in meaning between the two tenses.

Examples:

- I **have lived** in England for 3 years.
- I **have been living** in England for 3 years.
- I've **studied** English since 2017.
- I've **been studying** English since 2017.
- She **has worked** here for 6 months.
- She **has been working** here for 6 months.

Sometimes, there is a difference in meaning between the present perfect and the present perfect continuous.

1 FIRST SITUATION

The present perfect continuous can be used to emphasise the length of time that has passed, whereas the present perfect is generally neutral.

- She **has been working** for hours!
- She **has worked** for hours.

The sentence with the present perfect continuous tenses emphasises the length of time.

2 SECOND SITUATION

The present perfect is commonly used when talking about how much or how many. This isn't possible with the present perfect continuous.



- She **has eaten** 3 pieces of toast this morning.
- **NOT**: She **has been eating** 3 pieces of toast this morning.
- He's **drunk** 7 cups of coffee this afternoon.
- **NOT**: He's **been drinking** 7 cups of coffee this afternoon.

3 THIRD SITUATION

The present perfect continuous often focuses on the action itself, but the present perfect focuses on the completion of the action.

- I've **been watching** the TV series you recommended.
 - (I am still watching it.)
- I've **watched** the TV series you recommended.
 - (I have finished watching it.)
- She's **been seeing** a therapist.
 - (She continues to see the therapist.)
- She's **seen** a therapist.
 - (Her session(s) have finished.)

We can also use 'yet' and 'already' with the present perfect.

- I **have seen** the film **already**.
- I **have already seen** the film.
- **Have** you **seen** the film **yet**?

We use the difference between the present perfect and the present perfect continuous to talk about different kinds of results in the present.

We use the present perfect when the result comes from the action being finished, and we use the present perfect continuous when the result comes from the action itself.

- I've **done** all my chores, so I can come out tonight.
- I've **been doing** all my chores, so I am exhausted.



- I've **prepared** a big dinner, so you can come over to eat.
- I've **been preparing** a big dinner, so all my pans are dirty.

4 **FOURTH SITUATION**

We can use the present perfect continuous to emphasise that something isn't permanent.

- I've **been sleeping** badly.
 - (I don't usually sleep badly!)
- Normally I buy lunch at the canteen, but I **have been bringing** lunch from home.
- I've **been getting** up early to work out.
 - (I don't usually do this.)

**Activity**

Fill in the gaps with the verb in its correct form.

1. I _____ (walked) over 10km today.
2. I am sorry that my kitchen is messy! I _____ (cook).
3. How much sugar _____ (you, consume) today?
4. I _____ (read) the book you recommended and I've nearly finished!
5. How many energy drinks _____ (she, drink) this morning?
6. I _____ (read) the book you recommended and now I'm reading the sequel.
7. How long _____ (you, work) here?
8. She _____ (clean) a lot recently, which is out of character.
9. I _____ (study) biology since 2019.
10. I _____ (know) her for a long time.

Answers:

- | | |
|----------------------|--------------------------|
| 1. have walked | 6. have read |
| 2. have been cooking | 5. has she drunk |
| 3. have you consumed | 4. have been reading |
| 4. have been reading | 3. have you consumed |
| 5. has she drunk | 2. have been cooking |
| 6. have read | 1. have walked |
| 7. have you worked | OR have you been working |
| 8. has been cleaning | 9. have studied |
| 9. have studied | OR have been studying |
| 10. have known | |



'STOP' USING THE FUTURE TENSE

Today's lesson is all about looking towards the future as we explore the concept of 'future tenses,' but you'll soon discover why that term isn't entirely accurate. This lesson is chock-full of examples and includes a quiz to test your understanding. Ready to enhance your future expressions in English?

Is there actually a future tense?

You might be surprised to know that saying "**the future tense**" is incorrect.



Because there is no such thing as the future tense in English—**mind blown!**

If you look in most grammar books, you'll see a section named something like "*Talking about the future*", not "*Future tenses*". In fact, there are only two tenses in English: **the present** and **the past**. These tenses are further divided into aspects like **continuous** and **perfect**.

You might be wondering, "*What about the **simple** and **perfect continuous**?*" Linguists don't all agree on how many aspects there are in English. Many recognise only two (continuous and perfect). Others recognise four (simple, continuous, perfect and perfect continuous). It might be easier for you, as a learner, to think about **English having four aspects**.

We tend to call each **tense + aspect** "**a tense**", for example, the **present perfect tense** or the **past continuous tense**. It's just simpler to think about them like this, and it's probably what you've been taught at school and all through your English-learning journey.

Back to the future! A key feature in English tenses is verb inflection. In the present tense, for instance, we add **-s** to third-person singular verbs, and in the past tense, regular verbs often get an **-ed** suffix.



like → likes → liked

However, the future differs from the present and past tenses in a significant way: we don't have a specific verb inflection to indicate it. So, **there is no future tense**—technically.

But I think it's so much easier to think about the future as a tense in the same way as you think of the present and past tenses. So, I am taking a stand: **this lesson is about future tenses**. And I'm going to explain how you can use the future tenses in English.

Let's start with **will**. This is the word that people associate most strongly with the future. **Will** is a modal verb that can be used to talk about the future. We use it in what we call the **future simple**, **future continuous**, **future perfect simple** and **future perfect continuous**. Let's take a look at how these future tenses are used.

Future Simple

will + base verb

We use the future simple to-

- **make predictions.**
- **talk about decisions made at the moment of speaking.**
- **make offers and promises.**
 - *It **will be** a wonderful party, I just know it!*
 - *The dog's getting a bit boisterous. I'll **walk** him.*
 - *I'll **get** you another size to try on.*

Future Continuous

will + be + -ing verb



We use the future continuous to **talk about temporary actions and events that will be in progress at a time later than now.**

- *This time tomorrow, we'll **be sitting** down to dinner at my dream restaurant.*
- *I'll **be walking** to work tomorrow as my car is at the mechanic's.*

Future Perfect Simple

will + have + past participle

We use the future perfect simple to **talk about events that will be finished at a certain time later than now.** It's like we walk into the future and then turn around and look back.

- *We **will** definitely **have arrived** by 7pm.*
- *They'll **have** already **eaten** before they come round, so we don't need to feed them.*

Future Perfect Continuous

will + have been + -ing verb

We use the future perfect continuous **to emphasise the duration of an event that will be happening at a time later than now.** It's similar to the future perfect simple in that we look back from a time in the future.

- *In six months' time, we **will have been working** here for seven years.*
- *By this time next week, I **will have been travelling** for four months.*

A quick note about the future perfect simple and continuous here. With some verbs, you can use either tense **with no change in meaning.** One of those verbs is **work**.



- *In six months' time, we **will have worked / been working** here for seven years.*

They mean exactly the same thing. In the future perfect continuous, there is more of a feeling of emphasis on just how long you've worked there, but really you can use either.

Other verbs like this include **live**, **play** and **teach**. However, with lots of verbs, like **read**, you can't use them interchangeably.

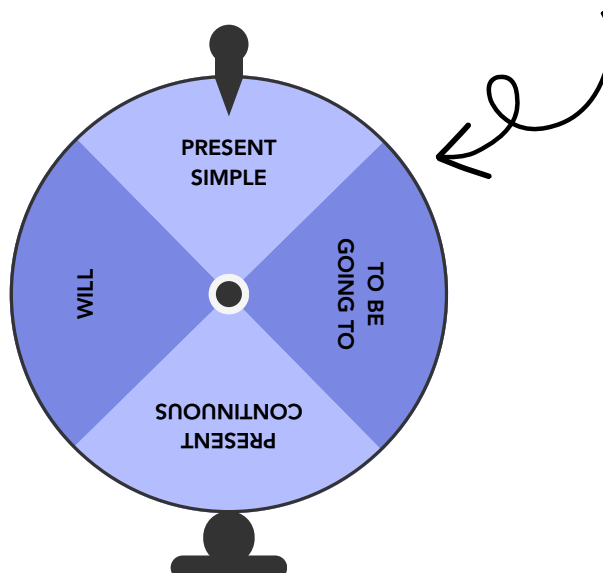
- *By tomorrow night, I **will have been reading** this book for two months.*

This means you won't have finished the book, and you cannot simply replace **will have been reading** with **will have read**. If you did, the sentence would not be grammatically correct because '**will have read**' means you will be finished reading.

Those are your four future tenses. Sorry, Grammar Police.

Talk About The Future In Other Ways

There are, of course, other ways to talk about the future apart from **will**. And we're going to look at them now using my **Wheel of Fortune!** (Or my future tenses wheel.)



As you can see, we have **will**, which I've already talked about. We can also see **to be going to**.

To Be Going To

be going to + base verb

We use **to be going to** in two main ways:

- to make predictions based on present evidence
 - *John is so drunk! He's **going to have** a terrible hangover tomorrow.*
- to talk about plans and intentions
 - *I'm **going to spend** the day at home tomorrow, just chilling.*

When the verb in the infinitive is **go**, we often shorten the sentence:

- *I'm **going** [to go] **shopping** later.*

Present Continuous

We use the present continuous to **talk about plans and arrangements**. Yes, plans again. There is often little difference between the present continuous and to be going to when we're talking about plans. However, when **we use the present continuous we have made a firm decision to do something**.

What do I mean by a '**firm decision**'? It usually means I know exactly what I'm doing, where, when and with whom. Often, but not always, we have arranged to do something. Look at these examples:

- *I **am having** lunch with my friend Claire tomorrow. (arrangement)*
- *We're **spending** the summer on a yacht in Croatia. (probably booked, but if not, very definitely happening)*

You could say—

- *We're **going to spend** the summer on a yacht in Croatia.*

This is a plan, but it's unlikely that you've booked it, and it just feels less certain than when we use the **present continuous**.

We **don't use the present continuous** to make predictions when an event is outside of our control.

- *The sky is so dark. It's ~~raining~~ **going to rain** in a few minutes.*

And we don't use it to talk about permanent situations in the future.

- *We are ~~living~~ **going to live** in the countryside for the rest of our lives.*

Present Simple

And finally, I want to talk about the present simple, another tense that, rather confusingly, we use to talk about the future. We use the present simple to **talk about timetabled or scheduled events**.

- *Our plane **leaves** at 2:10 tomorrow morning.*
- *The exam **finishes** at 7, so pick me up then.*



Activity

Choose the correct answer for each question.

1) The conference _____ tomorrow at 5pm.

- a. begins
- b. is beginning
- c. will begin

2) "Our flight departs at 9am," is an example of which tense?

- a. Present simple
- b. Future simple
- c. Present continuous

3) What is the structure for 'be going to'?

- a. be going to + base verb
- b. be going to + past participle
- c. be going to + -ing verb

4) By this time next year, I _____ my degree.

- a. will get
- b. will have got
- c. am going to get

5) This time tomorrow, we _____ to New York.

- a. will fly
- b. will be flying
- c. will have been flying

6) _____ your grandparents this weekend?

- a. Do you visit
- b. Will you have visited
- c. Are you going to visit

7) How many tenses are there in the English language according to traditional grammar?

- a. three
- b. two
- c. four

8) What do we often use the future simple tense for?

- a. to make predictions
- b. to discuss plans
- c. to emphasise duration

9) "It will rain tomorrow," is -

- a. a prediction
- b. an offer
- c. a plan

10) I _____ to the pub later today.

- a. go
- b. will have gone
- c. am going to go

Answers:

c (01 a (6 a (8 b (4 b (5 c (7 b (8 a (9 a (10) c



5 TENSES - 90% OF ENGLISH

In this lesson, we will look at the most commonly used grammar tenses in English. I will also teach you some of the everyday situations in which you can use each of these tenses. Don't forget to do the quiz at the end to check your understanding of each verb tense.

VERB TENSES

Technically, there are only **three verb tenses**: the present, past and future. But we have **4 different aspects** within these tenses: the simple, continuous, perfect simple and perfect continuous. When we combine these 4 aspects with the 3 verb tenses, we get what we typically refer to as the **12 verb tenses**.

Let's have a quick review of each:

Present

- **Present Simple**: used for general truths, habits and permanent situations.
- **Present Continuous**: used for actions happening now or around the present moment.
- **Present Perfect**: used for past actions with a connection to the present or for experiences.
- **Present Perfect Continuous**: used for actions that started in the past and are ongoing up to the present.

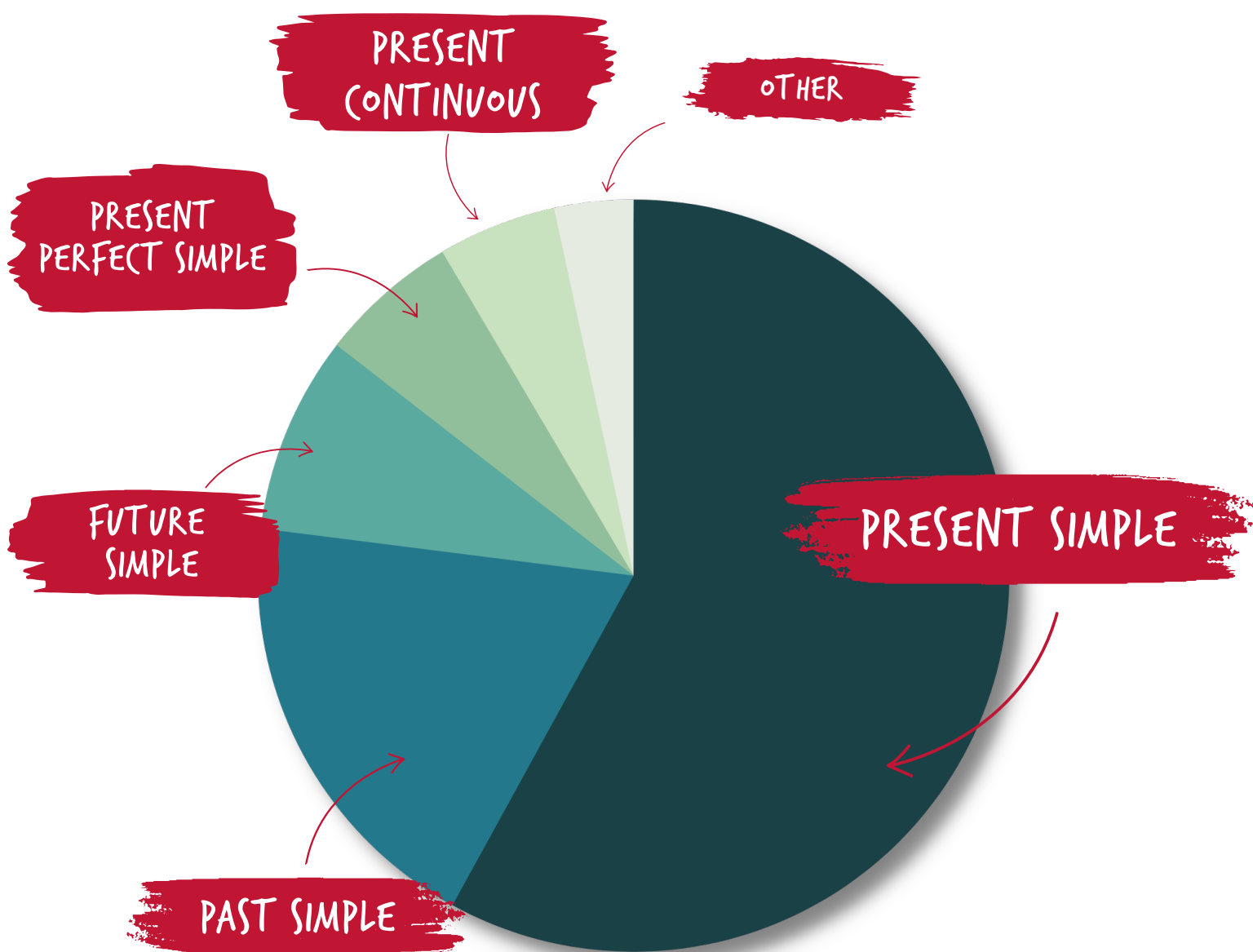
Past

- **Past Simple**: used to talk about completed actions in the past.
- **Past Continuous**: used for actions that were in progress at a specific time in the past.
- **Past Perfect**: used for actions completed before a specific time in the past.
- **Past Perfect Continuous**: used for actions that started in the past, continued and were completed before another past event.

Future

- **Future Simple:** used for actions that will happen in the future.
- **Future Continuous:** used for actions that will be in progress at a specific time in the future.
- **Future Perfect:** used for actions that will be completed before a specific time in the future.
- **Future Perfect Continuous:** used for actions that will have started in the past, present or future, continue, and be completed before another future event.

THE MOST COMMONLY USED TENSES



As you can see in the chart, not all verb tenses are created equal. According to research, the five most common English verb tenses are—

1. **The Present Simple**
2. **The Past Simple**
3. **The Future Simple**
4. **The Present Perfect Simple**
5. **The Present Continuous**

The small purple sliver on the chart contains the other 7 verb tenses.

But don't let this chart fool you. Each and every verb tense has its time and place, but for general, day-to-day conversations, these five are going to be your bread and butter.

Now let's go ahead and see how you can start using each of these tenses to the best of your ability.

THE PRESENT SIMPLE

As you just learnt, the **Present Simple** makes up a large portion of daily communication, and rightfully so.

Let's look at some of the most common uses of the Present Simple.

1. To talk about facts and statements that are always true

- Most people **prefer** to shop online.
- The supermarket **is** busy on Saturday mornings.

2. Statements that are true in the present

- You **are** my best friend, Jasmine!
- I can't **bake** to save my life — **look** at this cake!

3. Routine actions or habits in the present, often used with an adverb of frequency.

- Do you always **bike** to work?



- I never **see** her in yoga class these days.

4. To refer to scheduled events in the future

- Carmine's holiday officially **starts** on the 5th of October.
- My stag do **kicks off** at 10pm at Boots and Brews!

5. To give directions or instructions

- **Mix** the flour and water together to create a thick paste.
- To get to the bookshop, **walk** down to the corner and **take** a left.

As you can probably tell from our examples, these kinds of statements and questions make up a large portion of our daily conversations.

THE PAST SIMPLE

The Past Simple is the second most used verb tense because we use it to talk about completed actions in the past, and we love to talk about the past. Look at a news article or pick up your favourite book; most of them rely heavily on the Past Simple tense.

The Past Simple is commonly used to:

1. Describe actions that occurred at a specific time in the past.

- I **visited** Greece last summer with my girlfriend.

2. Narrate a series of past events

- Yolanda **woke** up, **brushed** her teeth and **headed off** to the office.

3. Express habitual or repeated actions in the past

- Every morning, Ben **watered** his plants and **fed** his dog.

4. Discuss past states or conditions

- We **were** so tired after our long hike yesterday.



THE FUTURE SIMPLE

The Future Simple tense allows us to talk about what's going to happen at a time after the present moment. It's used as a way to predict outcomes, express intentions, make plans and talk about expectations.

The Future Simple tense is pretty straightforward as it only uses 'will' and the base form of a verb. It is commonly used when talking about spontaneous decisions, predictions, promises, offers or requests.

1. spontaneous decisions:

- *I'm pretty hungry; I **will order** some food.*

2. predictions:

- *The weather forecast says it **will rain** tomorrow.*

3. promises:

- *I **will get** to the office 20 minutes early to get everything set up.*

4. offers:

- *Mum **will be** happy to help you with your project if you need it.*

5. requests:

- ***Will** you please **pass** me the salt?*

THE PRESENT PERFECT SIMPLE

It's time to talk about the **Present Perfect Simple**. Don't let its long and slightly confusing name fool you; it's actually quite an easy tense to master. Let's look at when and how we use it.

The Present Perfect Simple is a verb tense that is used to connect the past to the present. It is formed by using the auxiliary verb 'have' or 'has' with the past participle of the main verb.

We use the Present Perfect Simple to talk about:



1. Unfinished states or actions that started in the past

- He's **been** in his new position for about two weeks.

2. Completed actions with relevance to the present

- My dad **has** just **pulled up** to the house.

3. Life events and experiences

- They **have travelled** around Asia and most of Europe.

4. Actions or events at an unspecified time in the past

- Yeah, we've **tried** that recipe!

THE PRESENT CONTINUOUS

We usually use the **Present Continuous** tense to describe actions that are happening at the present moment or around the present time. It focuses on actions that are in progress or temporary situations.

We use the Present Continuous to talk about a few different situations, like:

1. Describing things happening right now

- Debra **is whipping** up some delicious banana pancakes.

2. Talking about activities that are not permanent

- I'm **giving** this workout plan a shot for a month to see how it makes me feel.

3. Discussing plans or events that will happen in the future

- Mark **isn't going** to that conference next month. He changed his mind.

4. Actions happening around a specific time

- I'm **working** this morning, but I'll be free this afternoon.

5. Describing things that are gradually changing or improving

- The city **is** slowly **becoming** more eco-friendly with new recycling programs and bike lanes.





Activity

Choose the correct answer for each question.

1) This sentence is written in the Present Perfect Simple.

They finished the project ahead of schedule.

- a. True
- b. False

2) The Present Continuous tense is commonly used to:

- a. talk about actions that started in the past
- b. describe things happening right now
- c. ask about intentions and make plans

3) Which verb tense is used in the following sentence?

Martina plays the violin exceptionally well.

- a. The Past Simple
- b. The Present Perfect Simple
- c. The Present Simple

4) Which verb tense is used to talk about completed actions in the past?

- a. Present Perfect Simple
- b. Past Simple
- c. Future Simple

5) Which verb would put this sentence in the Present Continuous tense?

The company _____ a new software application for its users.

- a. is developing
- b. developed
- c. will develop

6) The most commonly used verb tense is the Present Simple.

- a. True
- b. False

7) The Present Perfect Simple is used to connect:

- a. the past to the future
- b. the past to the present
- c. the present to the future

8) Which verb tense is used in the following sentence?

We will have a meeting at 3pm tomorrow.

- a. The Present Perfect Simple
- b. The Future Simple
- c. The Past Simple

Answers:

1) b 2) b 3) c 4) b 5) a 6) a 7) c 8) b



16 Tenses

In this lesson, I will teach you all of the English tenses. So many of you have been requesting a tenses video. I say go big or go home. That's a great saying. It means either putting in all your effort or doing nothing at all. I'd personally rather put in all of my effort. So today, in under 30 minutes, we will go through all 16 tenses, including the conditionals. You will walk away from this lesson with a much better understanding of English grammar.

I'm going to give you loads of examples so that you can learn them and use them yourself. Firstly, I think it's best to have an overview; then, we can go into each group more in-depth. I know that going over 16 tenses all in one lesson may seem like a lot, and it is. This is a big lesson, but they share many characteristics. So, seeing them all together makes learning and remembering easier. Let's go through them.

Tense	Example
Present Simple	I eat chocolate.
Present Continuous	I am eating chocolate.
Present Perfect	I have eaten chocolate.
Present Perfect Continuous	I have been eating chocolate.
Past Simple	I ate chocolate.
Past Continuous	I was eating chocolate.
Past Perfect	I had eaten chocolate.



Tense	Example
Past Perfect Continuous	I had been eating chocolate.
Future Simple	I will eat chocolate.
Future Continuous	I will be eating chocolate.
Future Perfect	I will have eaten chocolate.
Future Perfect Continuous	I will have been eating chocolate.
Conditional Simple	I would eat chocolate.
Conditional Continuous	I would be eating chocolate.
Conditional Perfect	I would have eaten chocolate.
Conditional Perfect Continuous	I would have been eating chocolate.

Can you see how many similarities there are between all of these tenses?

Now, let's look a little more closely. Starting with the present tenses, the first tense that you learn in English is usually the present simple, and that's for good reason.

It's actually the tense that native speakers use in around 50% of their written and spoken communication. We do use the other present tenses quite often too, so they are all really, really important.



The Present Simple

This is used to talk about general statements, habits and facts.

- I **work** on Tuesdays.

Structure

subject + base verb (except in the third person singular)

This always catches my students out when they're relatively new to learning English. In the third person singular, we add an 's'.

I	work. play. eat.	He	works. cleans. smells.
You		She	
We		It	
They			

Another exception is the verb 'to be'. It has its own forms.

I	am	He	is
You	are	She	
We		It	
They			



As I said before, we use the present simple to talk about general statements, facts and habits. We also use it to talk about scheduled events like plane and train times.

- I **am** a woman. My name **is** Lucy. (a general statement of fact)
- Mary **meets** her friends on Friday evenings. (a habit)
- The train to London **leaves** at 8 p.m. (a scheduled event in the future)
- Our dog **eats** the cat's food. (a habit)

A habit we're trying to conquer at the moment. We don't know why he started doing it, but he has since we moved house.

The Present Continuous

We use the present continuous to talk about things that are happening at the moment of speaking, but be careful; there is an exception. We can't use state verbs words like **hate**, **love** and **want**, for example.

Structure

subject + be + verb-ing

- I **am teaching** English.
- They **are baking** cookies.

We can also use this tense to talk about things we think are temporary. Compare these two sentences.

- James **lives** in Manchester.
- James **is living** in Manchester.

In the first sentence, I use the present simple because I think his state is more or less permanent. But in the second sentence, I use the present continuous because I think his situation might be temporary.



He's living in Manchester now, but I don't know what might happen in a few weeks or months. Perhaps he's studying there or working there for a short time.

Now, you will hear native speakers use state verbs in the present continuous in this form or to show this meaning.

- I **am loving** my Christmas jumper right now.

Love is a state verb. I'm not meant to use it, but it means right now.

You'll also hear people say:

- Oh no, I'**m hating** that song right now.

It means it's a temporary state. For some reason, right now, I don't enjoy that song temporarily. I'm hating it. So when you hear a teacher say, "Never use a state verb in the present continuous," take that with a pinch of salt.

We also use the present continuous to talk about arrangements. This means that we plan to do something in the future involving another person or business.

- I **am having** my haircut on Tuesday.
- Sarah **is meeting** her parents tomorrow.

There are plans, but they depend on someone else.

Let's take a look at some more examples.

- Kate **is studying** business. (temporary situation happening now)
- We **are meeting** our friend next Friday in Edinburgh. (arrangement involving someone else)

The Present Perfect

Structure

subject + have/has + past participle

There are three main ways that we use the present perfect in English. The first is to talk about things that started in the past and continue to the present. It's very important to remember that they are unfinished actions. When we talk about these events or states, we often mention how long they've been going on or when they started.

- I **have lived** in the UK all my life.
- She **has been** at university since 2020.
- William and I **have been** married for three months.

The second way that we use the present perfect is to talk about our experiences up to the present. When we do this, we don't talk about exactly when something happened. We are just generally telling somebody about our life experiences.

- She **has been** to Canada three times.
- We **have met** the Queen.
- I **have read** all of the Harry Potter books.

Finally, we also use the Present Perfect to talk about past events and actions that have consequences in the present.

- I **have eaten** breakfast, so I'm not hungry.
- Mike **has lost** his keys, so he's going to be late for work.

The Present Perfect Continuous

Structure

subject + have/has + been + verb-ing

We use the present perfect continuous to talk about something that started in the past and continues to the present, which might sound very similar to the present perfect. But there are a few key differences.

We often use it to talk about things that we have been doing uninterrupted that haven't finished. We use this tense to emphasise how long something has been happening.

- I've been watching that TV show for weeks.

I'm emphasising how long I have been watching the TV show.

- Ellen has been replying to emails for two hours already.

We use it to talk about things that have been done recently or lately.

- Look, it's been snowing.
- I've been practising my football skills a lot recently.

Remember, we generally don't use the present perfect continuous to talk about states.

I have been belonging to a band for a long time. ✗

I have belonged to a band for a long time. ✓

Some more examples.

- They've been trying to call you all day.
- She hasn't been feeling well lately.



The Past Simple

Structure

subject + regular verb + -ed

However, lots and lots of verbs are irregular and I do actually have a video on some of the most common irregular verbs that could be really useful, so I will leave that link down in the description box.

We use it to talk about events that happened before the present moment. These must be finished events or actions, and we often say when they happened, although that's not obligatory.

- I **went** to bed at 10 p.m. last night.
- Dennis **ate** a box of chocolates for breakfast.
- My husband **bought** me flowers last week.

The Past Continuous

Structure

subject + was/were + verb-ing

We can use this tense to talk about actions or states. One way we use the past continuous is to say what was happening at a specific moment in the past.

- Tom **was cooking** dinner at 7pm yesterday.

We can also use it to give background information about something.

- Will **was speaking** to me whilst I was trying to record a video.
- It **was snowing** when I went outside.



We also use it to say that an ongoing action was interrupted by another action. In this case, it's usually paired with another clause in the past simple.

- We **were eating** dinner when he **arrived**.
- They **were chatting** about their holiday when Ben **called** them.

The Past Perfect

Structure

subject + had + past participle

The past perfect tense is used to talk about events that happened before another event or up to a certain time in the past. Again, it is often used with the past simple.

- When I **arrived** at the bus stop, the bus **had already** left.
- You **had travelled** to ten countries before your second birthday.
- She **had worked** at the company for five years before it **closed**.
- We **had already eaten** dinner, so we **weren't** hungry when dinner was served.

The Past Perfect Continuous

Structure

subject + had been + verb-ing

Now, the past perfect and the past perfect continuous are often used interchangeably by native English speakers; there's no difference in overall meaning.



Take a look at these two sentences.

- I **had worked** there for five years when the company closed.
- I **had been working** there for five years when the company closed.

There's no real difference. We can say either. However, you should use the continuous form in these two situations: If you are talking about an action in the past that continued up to a certain time and continued after it, or if you're talking about a repeated action that happened in the past up to a certain point.

- They **had been walking** for hours before they decided that they were lost.
- The orchestra **had been practising** for months before the concert happened.

The Future Simple

Structure

subject + will + base verb

We can use it to talk about things that we think will happen in the future.

- I think it **will rain** tomorrow.
- I'm sure you **'ll love** this book.

We can also use it to make offers or promises.

I'll help you carry those boxes.

Richard **will call** you tomorrow.

And finally, we can use it to talk about facts in the future.

It **will be** our first wedding anniversary next year.

Our house **will be** 300 years old soon.



The Future Continuous

Structure

subject + will be + verb-ing

This tense is used to talk about actions that will be in progress at a certain point in time. These actions will start and end in the future, but we don't know when.

- I **will be eating** dinner at 8pm tomorrow. (I don't know when I'll finish)

It also indicates that an action will be carried out over a period of time, not simply in an instant.

- I'll **be playing** tennis tomorrow.

That will be a considerable amount of time. Maybe 30 minutes to an hour, not just a second.

The Future Perfect

Structure

subject + will have + past participle

We use the future perfect to talk about actions or states that will be completed before a certain point of time in the future. We often use time clauses with the future perfect, like 'by' or 'when I'm older'.

- I **will have retired** by the time I'm 65. ('by' shows the final point)
- You **will have finished** the popcorn before the film starts.
- Come over at 9pm. My parents **will have left** by then.



The Future Perfect Continuous

Structure

subject + will have been + verb-ing

This tense describes actions that will be continuing at a certain point in the future. When you use this tense, you're thinking about the duration of that action up to a certain point in time.

- She **will have been living** in Cardiff for three months in August.
- When I retire next month, I **will have been working** here for three years.

Like with most other continuous tenses, we don't usually use state verbs.

- I **will have had** my cat for five years this Christmas. ✓
- I will have been having my cat for five years this Christmas. ✗

You also can't use the future perfect continuous to talk about finished actions. You just have to use the future perfect instead.

Conditional Tenses

Finally, the last four tenses are the conditional tenses. We use these tenses to talk about hypothetical situations or an event that depends on another event or state. These conditional tenses often form part of conditional sentences but don't always have to.

The Conditional Simple

Structure

subject + would + base verb

We use this to talk about hypothetical actions that started in the past and continued.

- I **would travel** in first class.
- She **would walk** to work.

Now, these sentences don't really have much meaning on their own, so they're usually coupled with another idea.

- I **would travel** in first class **if I won** the lottery.
- She **would walk** to work **if she lived** closer.

'Would' can be replaced with 'could', 'should' or 'might', but this does change the meaning.

- He **could get** a dog if he wanted.
- You **should see** a doctor.
- I **might go** to the beach tomorrow.

The Conditional Continuous

Structure

subject + would be + verb-ing

When we use the conditional continuous, we put the focus on the duration of a hypothetical action. This means that we use this tense to talk about a longer action. We want to emphasise how long an action would take.



It expresses an unfinished or continuing hypothetical action, an action which is the probable result of an unreal condition.

- I **would be writing** emails if I was at work. (I'm not at work, so I'm not writing emails.)
- He **would be walking** his dog right now if he hadn't broken his ankle. (he has broken his ankle, so he's not walking his dog)

You can use 'could', 'should' and 'might' in these sentences, but again, it changes the meaning.

- You **should be unpacking** the shopping I just bought.
- I **could be sitting** on a beach in Jamaica right now.

The Conditional Perfect

Structure

subject + would have + past participle

We use the conditional perfect tense when we want to change the past. Of course, we can't really change the past, so this is hypothetical. We talk about what we would have done.

- I **would have told** John not to come.
- I **would have bought** that house, but I couldn't afford it at the time.
- She **would have cooked** a bigger meal, but she didn't know you were coming again.

You can replace it with 'could', 'should' or 'might'.

- I **could have bought** that house, but I didn't.
- You **should have told** me.
- We **could have gone** if we'd known about it.
- They **might have said**, but I can't remember.



The Conditional Perfect Continuous

Structure

subject + would have been + verb-ing

We use it to talk about the hypothetical results of an action that started in the past. We use the continuous tense to focus on the duration. As I said before, we look at conditional grammar in more detail in my conditional video, which I have linked in the description box.

- I **would have been wearing** my red dress if I had washed it.
- He **would have been working** in Dubai if he hadn't taken the job in London.

Again. You can use it with 'could', 'should' and 'might'.

- You **should have been feeling** better yesterday.
- She **could have been living** in Japan if she had taken that language course at university.

Right? That is it for today's lesson. I can't believe we've covered the 16 tenses. That's amazing.





Activity

Put the words in brackets into the correct tense.

The Present Tenses

1. I _____ (learn) English right now.
2. We _____ (eat) there before but we can go if you'd like.
3. My name _____ (be) Andy.
4. I'm so tired! I _____ (work) all day!

The Future Tenses

9. I think it _____ (rain) tomorrow so we should stay at home.
10. I _____ (study) for five years by the time I finally graduate.
11. Ollie _____ (finish) his project by the time we see you next.
12. This time next week, I _____ (sit) on a beach in the Caribbean.

The Past Tenses

5. When she finally arrived, I _____ (wait) for almost an hour.
6. I _____ on holiday to France last year.
7. Marco _____ (talk) to his mum when I met him.
8. Claire _____ (drink) all her water before she started the hike.

The Conditional Tenses

13. I _____ (cook) a vegetarian meal if I had known Dave was coming.
14. Katie _____ (cycle) to work if she lived closer to the office.
15. They _____ (live) in New Zealand now if they had got the job.
16. We _____ (work) today if they hadn't given us all a day off.

Answers:

The Present Tenses: 1. am learning 2. have eaten 3. is 4. have been working

The Future Tenses: 9. will rain 10. will have been studying 11. will have finished 12. will be sitting

The Past Tenses: 5. had been waiting 6. went 7. was talking 8. had drunk

The Conditional Tenses: 13. would have cooked 14. would cycle 15. would be living 16. would have been working



PRONUNCIATION OF -ED

Ever wondered why 'wanted' and 'loved' sound different at the end? This lesson will demystify the pronunciation of -ed endings in English. There are actually three ways to pronounce this common suffix, and the choice depends on the sound at the end of the root word. Understanding these rules will help improve your pronunciation and make your English sound more natural. Let's explore how to master the -ed sound!

1 -ed root verbs end with /ɪd/

If the root word ends in /t/ or /d/, the -ed ending is pronounced **/ɪd/**.

- parted - /'pɑ:tɪd/
- ended - /'endɪd/
- tested - /'testɪd/
- needed - /'ni:dɪd/

2 -ed root verbs end with /d/

If the root word doesn't end in /t/ or /d/ - does it end in a vowel or a voiced consonant? Does it end with voice? (This means you can feel the vibrations in your throat when you come to finish saying the word.)

We match voiced with voiced.

If this applies to the root, then -ed is pronounced **/d/**:

- dine - /daɪnd/
- love - /lʌvd/
- comply - /kəm'plaɪd/
- remember - /rɪ'membəd/

3 -ed root verbs end with /t/

If the root verb ends with an unvoiced consonant sound, then -ed is pronounced **/t/**:

We match unvoiced with unvoiced (otherwise it would be quite hard to say!)

- clap - /klæpt/
- kick - /kɪkt/
- dance - /dɑːnst/
- wash - /wɒʃt/

Consonant Sound Guide**/ɪd/**

/t/
wanted

/d/
decided

/d/

/b/
robbed

/v/
lived

/z/
amazed

/g/
rigged

/n/
fined

/m/
climbed

/ŋ/
winged

/dʒ/
judged

/ð/
soothed

/l/
called

/ʒ/
camouflaged

/r/
remembered
(US only)

/t/

/p/
helped

/f/
sniffed
laughed

/s/
missed
danced

/k/
asked

/tʃ/
matched

/ʃ/
washed

/θ/
unearthed





Activity

Read aloud and mark the phonetic ending (/t/ /d/ or /ɪd/) above each -ed word. Check your results below. The first has been done for you.

As I have told you before, I ^{/d/}1. **loved** living in Seville. I always 2. **envisioned** myself living there long-term. I had also 3. **lived** in Madrid, but for some reason, Seville really 4. **inspired** me. It had nearly everything I 5. **wanted**, so I 6. **promised** to myself that I would move there in the future. I 7. **moved** back to the UK to finish my studies. When I 8. **finished**, I 9. **rented** a room from my parents and 10. **started** my teaching business. One day, I was 11. **invited** to a New Years Eve party. I didn't want to go, but I 12. **pushed** myself. I 13. **noticed** a very handsome man there, but we mostly 14. **ignored** each other the whole night. One day, this man 15. **messaged** me and 16. **asked** if I would participate in a charity dating show that he had 17. **organised**. I 18. **responded** with a 'yes' and 19. **prepared** for the event. In the end, that man won a date with me, and I 20. **postponed** my plans to move to Seville. Eventually I simply 21. **cancelled** them. I 22. **discovered** that home is not a place - it's a person. I have 23. **visited** Seville every year since, and that is enough for me.

Answers:

16. /t/	8. /t/
15. /d/	7. /d/
14. /d/	6. /t/
13. /t/	5. /ɪd/
12. /t/	4. /d/
11. /ɪd/	3. /d/
10. /ɪd/	2. /d/
9. /ɪd/	1. /d/
23. /ɪd/	
22. /d/	
21. /d/	
20. /d/	
19. /d/	
18. /ɪd/	
17. /d/	



USED TO / USE TO / BE USED TO / GET USED TO / WOULD DO

Have you ever struggled with explaining how things were different in the past? This lesson will help you master the tricky phrase 'used to' and its variations. We'll explore how to talk about past habits, states that have changed, and even how to describe getting accustomed to new situations. By the end, you'll be able to confidently discuss past experiences and how things have changed over time. Let's dive into the world of 'used to'!

1 USED TO & USE TO

We use '**used to**' to talk about past habits which we don't do in the present, or past states which are no longer true. We use 'used to' with the base form of a verb.

- I **used to** do yoga (but now I don't have time.)
- I **used to** go to a language school (but I finished the course.)
- I **used to** live in Seville (but now I live in England.)
- I **used to** be a waitress (but now I am a teacher.)

You might have noticed that sometimes we say 'use to' instead of 'used to'. This is a point of confusion for many of my students. In questions and negatives (apart from never), we use 'use', not 'used'.

- I didn't **use to** like avocados, but now I love them!
- Did you **use to** work at the corner shop?
- He didn't **use to** care about his appearance, but now he takes pride in it.
- Did they **use to** go to the same school as us?

2 WOULD

When someone is telling a story about the past, you might hear them use **would + base verb**:



- When I lived in Seville, we **would** eat lunch at 4pm.
- When I was studying Spanish, I **would** watch Spanish TV shows.

We can use **would + base verb** to talk about past habits or repeated actions, but we cannot use it to talk about past states.

- 'I **would** live in Seville.'
 - **does not mean the same thing as**
- 'I **used** to live in Seville.'

3 TO BE USED TO

When we want to talk about things that we are accustomed to or things that feel normal, we use:

to be used to + verb-ing

- I **am used to** running in the cold weather, so I don't mind doing it. (Running in the cold weather is what I am accustomed to.)
- My fiancé Will **is used to** working hard, so when we go on holiday he becomes restless. (Working hard is normal for Will.)

We also use to be **used to + noun/pronoun**:

- I live in the countryside, so I **am used to** mud.
- He is very handsome, so he **is used to** compliments.
- My sister is annoying, but I **am used to** her.

The verb 'to be' can be put into any tense:

- When I started waitressing I wasn't used to carrying trays of drinks.
- Soon I'll be used to taking public transport and it won't be so intimidating.

4 TO GET USED TO

We use '**to get used to + verb-ing OR noun/pronoun**' to talk about a change in what you are accustomed to. This can also be used in any tense.

- At first, I didn't like stretching after running, but **I got used to it**.
- I **am getting used to public speaking**.
- I hope I'll **get used to driving** in London soon!



Activity

Fill in the gaps with A, B, or C. The answers are below.

1. When I started waitressing I needed help with carrying trays, but now I _____ them by myself.

- a) used to carry
- b) am used to carrying
- c) get used to carrying

2. I _____ English every day, but now I don't have time.

- a) use to reading
- b) use to read
- c) used to read

3. Don't worry, it is easy to learn this grammar. You _____ it in no time!

- a) will get used to
- b) are used to
- c) used to use

4. I was surprised to see her running - she _____ when I knew her.

- a) didn't use to run
- b) didn't used to run
- c) didn't use to running

5. When I had to take the train to work I _____ very early.

- a) used to getting up
- b) used to get up
- c) use to getting up

6. When I was younger _____ to the shops with my grandma to buy sweets.

- a) I got used to go
- b) I used to going
- c) I would go

7. Whenever we went to London we always _____ in the Grand Hotel.

- a) used to stay
- b) used to staying
- c) got used to staying

8. When you were a teenager did you _____ to rap music?

- a) use to listening
- b) used to listen
- c) use to listen

9. She didn't _____ about fashion but now she spends a lot of money on clothes.

- a) used to care
- b) use to care
- c) used to be care

10) I don't like revising for exams but I _____ it.

- a) am got used to it
- b) am get used to it
- c) am getting used to it

Answers:

1) b 2) c 3) a 4) b 5) c 6) a 7) b 8) c 9) a 10) c



Have Been, Has Been and Had Been

In today's lesson, we're focusing on the often-confusing structures 'have been', 'has been' and 'had been'. We'll break down these forms with practical examples and helpful tips, ensuring you understand their usage in different contexts. To make sure you've got it all down, we'll wrap up with a quiz to test your knowledge.

What will you learn in today's lesson?

This lesson is quite long and in-depth, so before we start, I'm going to tell you exactly what I'll be talking about so you know what to expect.

- **Subject-Verb Agreement:** understand which subjects pair with 'have', 'has' and 'had'.
- **Sentence Formation:** learn to construct positive and negative sentences and questions with 'have been', 'has been' and 'had been'.
- **Pronunciation & Contractions:** master the pronunciation of these words and their contracted forms.
- **Key Uses Exploration:**
 - Discuss travel experiences
 - Describe ongoing states or actions, with a focus on 'for' and 'since'
 - Examine the narrative of two past events or actions
 - Employ the passive voice to highlight the object of a sentence
- **Additional Applications:** gain insight into the varied applications of 'have been', 'has been' and 'had been'.
- **Quiz Time:** a short review of the quiz from the video lesson.

Are you ready to finally master '**have been**', '**has been**' and '**had been**'?

Let's get started with our first topic on the next page.



1 Subject-Verb Agreement

First, I'm going to talk about the basics. We use **'have been'** and **'has been'** in the present perfect tenses.

Here's a quick review of the present perfect constructions -

	Positive	Negative	Question
Present Perfect Simple	subject + have/has + past participle	subject + have/has + not + past participle	have/has + subject + past participle
	My mum has seen that film.	My mum has not seen that film.	Have you seen that film?
Present Perfect Continuous	subject + have/has + been + -ing verb	subject + have/has + not + been + -ing verb	have/has + subject + been + -ing verb
	We have been working there for years.	I haven't been working since the pandemic.	Has he been working online?

I, you, we, they and **plural nouns** go with **'have been'**.

- **I** have been
- **You** have been
- **The books** have been
- **My parents** have been

He, she, it and **singular** and **uncountable nouns** go with **'has been'**.

- **She** has been
- **It** has been
- **London** has been
- **The bread** has been (bread is uncountable)



And now let me refresh your memory of the past perfect tenses before we continue.

	Positive	Negative	Question
Past Perfect Simple	subject + had + past participle	subject + had + not + past participle	Had + subject + past participle
	Katherine had approved my time off before she left.	They had not been to that restaurant before I took them.	Had you done pottery before today?
Past Perfect Continuous	subject + had + been + -ing verb	subject + had + not + been + -ing verb	Had + subject + been + -ing verb
	I had been living in my dad's flat up until I moved to Madrid.	I hadn't been feeling well for a few days so I decided to go to the doctor's.	Had you been studying for your exams before the holiday started?

We use '**had been**' with **all subjects** in the **past perfect tenses**.

- I had been
- He had been
- Our children had been
- The tea had been

2 Positive and Negative Sentences and Questions

In **positive sentences**, the structure is -

positive = subject + have/has/had been... .

In **negative sentences**, we put 'not' between 'have, has or had' and 'been':



negative = subject + have/has/had not been... .

In **questions**, we invert the subject-verb order and put 'have, has or had' before the subject:

questions = Have/Has/Had + subject + been... ?

I want to note here that we can use '**been**' (to be) as a **main verb** or an **auxiliary verb**.

'been' as a main verb	'been' as an auxiliary verb
' Been ' expresses the state or action being described. It is not followed by another verb.	' Been ' adds grammatical information to a sentence. It is followed by a main verb
I have been to France.	I have been <u>studying</u> English for 3 years

3 Pronunciation and Contractions

Before we get started with how these words are used, I want to go over the pronunciation.

'**Been**' is pronounced **/bi:n/** or **/bɪn/**. Both are correct, but **/bɪn/** is very common in faster, informal speech. It's also very common for speakers to use contractions with have/has or had been. For example, **I have been...** often becomes -

- **I've been** ➡ /aɪv bi:n/
- or
- **I've been** ➡ /aɪv bɪn/

So, listen out for the contracted forms '**I've**', '**you've**', '**we've**' and '**they've**.'



The same thing happens with **'has been'**, which reduces to **/z/** or **/s/**, for -

- **He's been** ➔ /hi:z bi:n/
- **She's been** ➔ /ʃi:z bi:n/
- **It's been** ➔ /ɪts bi:n/

And **'had been'**, which contracts to **/d/**, for example -

- **I'd been** ➔ /aɪd bi:n/
- **He'd been** ➔ /hi:d bi:n/

Except with the contraction of **'it had'**, which contracts to **/'ɪtəd/**. Notice the extra **/ə/** sound there, which adds an extra syllable.

Finally, we often contract a noun with **'have/has/had been'**.

- **The books've been** ➔ /'bʊksəv bi:n/
- **London's been** ➔ /'lʌndənz bi:n/
- **Our children'd been** ➔ /'tʃɪldrənəd bi:n/

4 Uses

Travel Experiences

Now let's talk about the first and easiest use of **'have been'**, **'has been'** and **'had been'**. This might be the easiest but it's where a lot of my students get confused and make mistakes. We often use **'have been'**, **'has been'** and **'had been'** when talking about travel experiences. For example -

- Will **has been** to London many times.

Note that it's **'been to London'** but just **'visited London'** without **'to'**. That's a common mistake.

This means that Will has visited London many times in his life up until now.



- I've **been** to France three times.

I have visited France three times in my life until now and I might go again in the future. Here are some more examples.

- **Has** Verity **been** to Cardiff?
- Yes, she has [been to Cardiff].
- No, she hasn't [been to Cardiff].
- **Have** you **been** to Australia?
- Yes, I have [been to Australia].
- No, I haven't [been to Australia].

These answers are usually shortened to '**Yes, I have.**' and '**No, I haven't.**'

Please note that we **can't talk about specific times** with 'have/has been' to talk about general travel experiences. If you want to say exactly when something happened, use the **past simple**.

I **have been** to Australia last year. ✗

I **went** to Australia last year. ✓

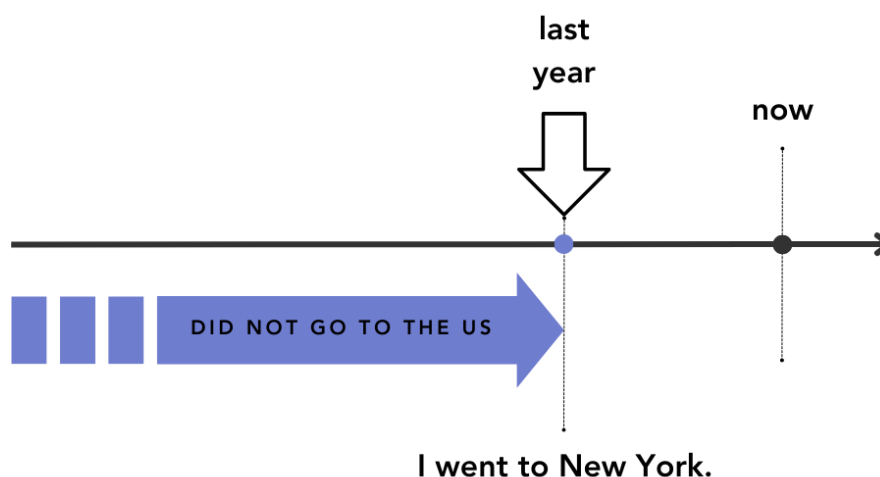
Now, I would like to mention something that lots of learners find confusing: '**have/has been**' and '**have/has gone**'.

have/has been	have/has gone
Use have/has been to say that someone went to a place and then returned. The visit is complete.	Use have/has gone to say that someone went to a place and has not returned.
Alicia has been to Mumbai.	Alicia has gone to Mumbai. She will be back next week.

You can also use '**had been**' when talking about travel experiences. We use 'had been' to say that **we travelled or didn't travel to a place before another event in the past**. For example -

- I **had never been** to the US before I visited New York last year.

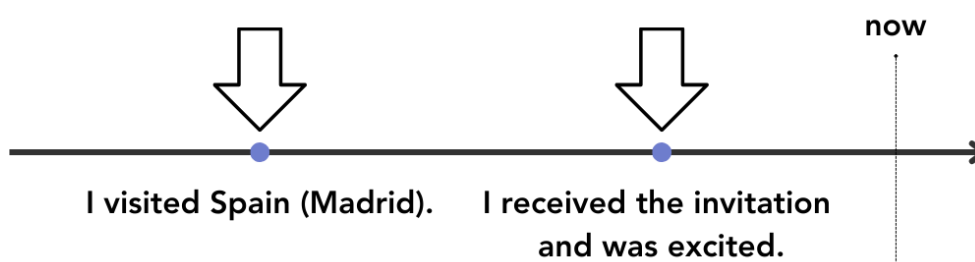
There are two past tenses here. 'I **had never been**' and 'I **visited**' both refer to the past. The sentence means that the first time in my life that I visited the US was when I went to New York last year.



Here's another example -

- I was excited to receive an invitation to their wedding in Barcelona. I **had been** to Spain before, but only to Madrid.

This sentence means that I received an invitation to the wedding in the past. I visited Spain at some point before I got the invitation, but not Barcelona, where the wedding was.



Unfinished States and Actions

In the next section, let's discuss the second use of 'have been' and 'has been'. We use 'have been' and 'has been' in the **present perfect simple** to talk about **states that started in the past and continue up to the present**.

For example -

- He **has been** a nurse for almost a year.
- He **has been** a nurse since last March.

He started working as a nurse last March and has had the job for almost a year. He is still a nurse now.

Here are some other common uses of the present perfect simple.

1	<u>To describe experiences and life events</u>
2	<u>To discuss recently completed actions</u>
3	<u>To talk about actions that happened at an unspecified time</u>

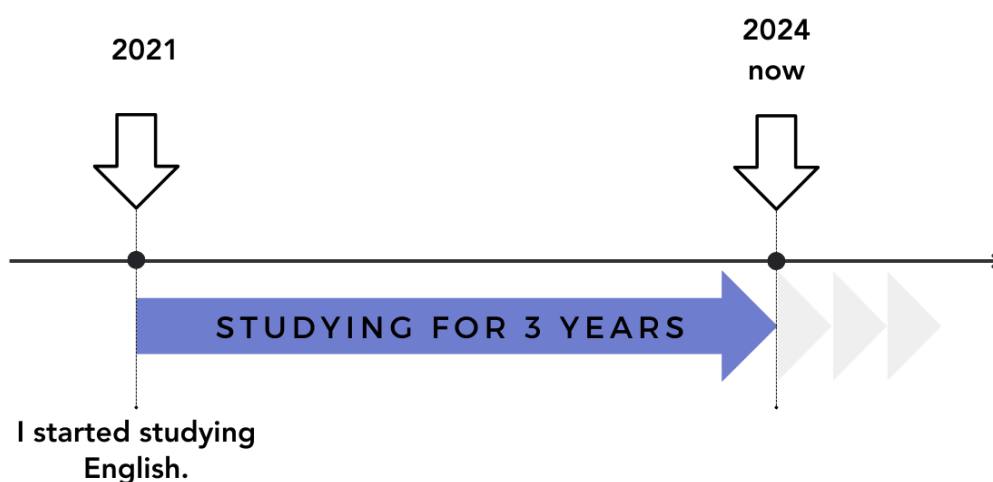
We use '**have been + -ing**' and '**has been + -ing**' in the **present perfect continuous** to talk about **actions that started in the past and continue up to the present**.

- I **have been studying** English for three years.
- I've **been studying** English since 2021.

2021 was my starting point for studying English. So, I started in 2021 and I have continued for three years until the present day. You don't know if I will continue studying English in the future. Using 'have been' or 'has been' does not tell you about the future.

Let's look at some of the other ways to use the present perfect continuous.

1	<u>To discuss actions with a result in the present</u>
2	<u>To emphasise the duration of actions</u>
3	<u>To talk about habits or repeated actions</u>
4	<u>To talk about processes or changes</u>



We often use the words '**for**' and '**since**' with the present perfect tenses. When we use 'for', we're talking about the duration of the activity or the period of time. So 'three years' is how long I have been studying English. When we say 'since', we are talking about the starting point. So, I started studying English in 2021.

Now, here are some more example sentences -

- William **has been watching** TV since midday.
- William's **been watching** TV for three hours.
(presuming it's 3 in the afternoon)

In the first sentence, William started watching TV at midday and he is still watching TV now. In the second sentence, he started watching TV three hours ago and he is still watching now.

- We've **been** together for 7 years.
- We've **been** together since 2017.

We got together seven years ago, in 2017, and we are still together now.

Two Past Events or Actions

Now let's take a closer look at '**had been**'. I'm going to take the sentences that we used to learn 'have been' and 'has been' and show you how they're used with 'had been'. This will help you to see how the meaning changes.

Let's start with our sentence about studying English. Here it is with 'had been' in the past perfect continuous.

- I **had been** studying English for three years when I went to London last year.

There are two past actions here. One continuous past action, 'I had been studying English' and a single finished action, 'I went to London'.

Now, I want to compare that sentence with our previous one with 'have been'.

- I **have been** studying English for three years.

Here, there is one action that continues up to the present.

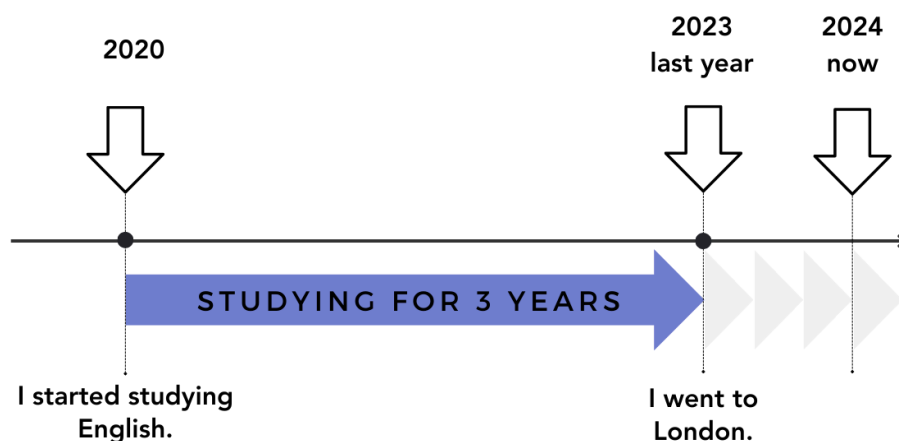
- I **had been** studying English for three years when I went to London last year.

We use 'had been' or 'had been + -ing' when there are two past events. The action with 'had been' began in the past and continued up to a more recent point in the past.



We use the **past simple** to talk about the action or event that happened second. In this case, the more recent point was 'last year' when I went to London.

We use the **past perfect continuous** for the action which happened first. We don't know if the action (studying English) continued beyond my trip.



Let's have a look at the other example sentences and change them to 'had been'.

- William **had been** watching TV for three hours when he stopped to do some housework.

The action 'had been watching' began first and continued until William realised it was time to start the housework.

- He'd **been** a nurse for 11 months when he quit his job.

In this case, he became a nurse and continued in the job for 11 months. Then he quit. This is an example of the **past perfect simple**. And the last example is a sad one :

- We **had been** together for 7 years when we broke up.

We were in a relationship for 7 years before we broke up.

The Passive Voice

Now, let's move on to the fourth and final use that I want to talk about in this video of 'have been', 'has been' and 'had been'. We use them in the **passive voice**.

Before we go any further, let's do a quick review of the passive voice. The passive voice is formed by combining the verb **'to be'** with the past participle. 'To be' indicates the tense in the passive voice.

Here are some more examples in different past, present and future tenses.

Active	Passive
Present Simple: Mark cleans the house daily.	Present Simple: The house is cleaned daily.
Past Continuous: They were writing a report.	Past Continuous: A report was being written.
Future Perfect: I will have washed the car by tomorrow.	Future Perfect: The car will have been washed by tomorrow.

Note that we don't typically use the passive voice in the **present perfect continuous, past perfect continuous** or **future perfect continuous** tenses.

It is common to use the passive voice -

1	<u>to focus on the object of a sentence</u>
2	<u>when the subject is unknown or unimportant</u>
3	<u>when the subject is obvious or not explicitly mentioned</u>
4	<u>to avoid responsibility or blame</u>

Alright, let's get back to the lesson. I tend to buy lots of things online for my dog, Diego. And, when I complete a purchase, I get an email saying,

- Your order **has been received**.

This sentence is in the passive voice. In the **active voice**, it would be -

- We **have received** your order.

The website uses the passive voice because 'we' (the seller) isn't important in this situation. The order is more important, so the focus of the sentence is on that.

After I've bought something, the shop sends my purchases to me. Then I often get a message from the courier saying this:

- Your parcel **has been** delivered.

Or, because I usually buy several things at once -

- Your parcels **have been** delivered.

The parcels are more important than the company or person who delivered them.

So, how do we use 'had been' in the passive voice?

This is quite advanced but it's important that you know it because I'm sure you will hear it.

We use 'had been' in the passive voice when there are two actions in the past. For example -

- My van **had been** repaired by the mechanic so it was as good as new.

Both of the events or actions were in the past. The first event that occurred is indicated with '**had been**' and the second with the **past simple**. So first the mechanic repaired my car and then it was as good as new.

Let's look at another example.

- By the time we arrived at the hotel, all the rooms **had been** booked for the night.

Again, we have two events in the past. First, people booked all of the rooms and then we arrived at the hotel. Very poor planning.

5 Extra Information

In this final section, I want to give you some extra information about when you will see 'have been', 'has been' and 'had been' used. I'm not going to explain these uses in great detail, but I want you to be aware of them.

- '**Have been**' after modal verbs

- We see 'have been' (but not 'has been') appear after modal verbs like '**might**' and '**must**'. Using 'have been' with different modal verbs could be a whole video in itself, so here are just a couple of examples -

- Maria **might have been** in Ghana last month. She goes every year in January.
- He **must have been** at work when you tried to call him.

- **The third conditional**

- You will also see 'have been' after a modal verb in the third conditional.
 - I **would have been** happy if you had come.
- And we use 'had been' in the third conditional, too.
 - If I **had been** to Greenland before, I **would have** told you about it.

- **'Has-been' as a noun**

- The final thing I want to draw your attention to is the use of 'has-been' /'hæz bi:n/ as a noun! Notice that there is a hyphen between 'has' and 'been'. A 'has-been' is a person who was important, famous or very good at something in the past but isn't any more. It's not a very nice thing to call someone, but you should recognise the word even if you don't use it.

6 Quiz Review

1. She has been waiting for her friends to arrive for over 30 minutes.

- The subject is 'she', so we use 'has been' not 'have been'. This is an example of the **present perfect continuous**, with a situation starting in the past and continuing to the present, with a focus on the duration.

2. Andy had been a teacher for almost 50 years when he retired.

- This is an example of the **past perfect simple**. We use 'had been' to describe the state of being a teacher. There are two past events - first, Andy was a teacher for almost 50 years and then he retired.

3. Have you ever been to London?

- In this question, we use the **present perfect simple** to ask about travel experiences. We use 'have' not 'has' because the subject is 'you'.



4. My bike has been stolen! How am I going to get home?

- This is the **present perfect simple passive**. 'My bike' could be replaced by the pronoun 'It', so we use 'has'.

5. Karim has never been to Mongolia, but he's planning to go next year.

- This negative statement is about a travel experience (or non-experience!). We use 'has' because 'Karim' could be replaced by 'He'.





Activity

Choose the correct answer for each question.

1. The feedback from customers _____
_____ very positive this quarter.
 - a. has been
 - b. have been
 - c. had been
2. _____ your friends ever _____
to your summer house by the lake?
 - a. Has / been
 - b. Have / been
 - c. Had / been
3. For the past week, the city _____
engulfed in heavy fog.
 - a. has been
 - b. had been
 - c. have been
4. Before moving to London, she _____
living in Paris for five years.
 - a. has been
 - b. had been
 - c. have been
5. Which sentence expresses an action
completed at an indefinite time before
now?
 - a. They had completed the project when the
manager arrived.
 - b. They completed the project last week.
 - c. They have completed the project
successfully.
6. Since the policy update, there _____
_____ improvements in morale.
 - a. has been
 - b. have been
 - c. had been
7. Why _____ the packages _____
delayed for so long?
 - a. has / been
 - b. had / been
 - c. have / been
8. My phone _____ missing since
yesterday.
 - a. has been
 - b. had been
 - c. have been
9. Which option illustrates a completed
action in the past before another past
action?
 - a. We have finished our homework.
 - b. We had finished our homework before
the movie started.
 - c. We have to finish our homework before
the movie starts.
10. The documents _____
reviewed.
 - a. has been
 - b. had been
 - c. have been

Answers:

1 a 2 b 3 b 4 b 5 c 6 b 7 c 8 b 9 b 10 b

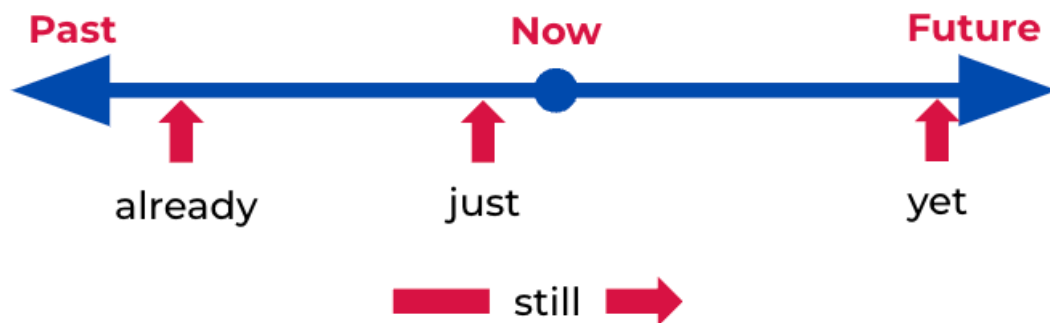


Still, Already, Just & Yet

Still, already, just & yet are commonly used adverbs in English. However, their usage can be a little confusing. Today, we are going to learn about their difference and correct usage.

1 Timing

To better understand their usage, we can divide these four words in order of when they happen.



As you can see above, the words 'already' and 'just' are used to talk about finished actions in the past, 'yet' talks about things that are planned to happen in the future. The tricky one is 'still', which can have different meanings depending on the grammar used with it.

We use the words 'already', 'just', 'yet' and 'still' mostly with Present Perfect grammar (have done) because they describe actions that relate to the present and make reference to the time when they happened.

Examples:

1. I've **just** finished my homework (a few minutes ago)
2. I've **already** watched that movie (sometime in the past)
3. I haven't been to the supermarket **yet**. (plan to do it soon)
4. I **still** haven't called my teacher. (plan to do it soon)

1 Meaning

Already

1. Describe something that has been completed in the near past.
 - 'You don't need to wash up. I've **already** done it.'
(Action likely happened several minutes ago)
2. Describe something that happened longer ago.
 - 'I don't want to travel to Spain. I've **already** been there!'
(Could have happened several years ago)
3. Express the idea that the action happened quicker than expected.
 - 'The test started 10 minutes ago, but she's **already** finished it!'
(The test is 30 minutes long)

Just

1. Describe something that happened a short time before now.
 - I've **just** finished dinner. Now time for some TV!
(Few seconds or minutes ago)
2. Describe something that happened in the recent past.
 - 'William has **just** come back from America.'
(Could be several days ago)
3. Expressing a precise or exact meaning.
 - 'That's **just** what I wanted to say!'
(exactly/precisely)

4. To describe a strong feeling about something.

- 'She is **just** an amazing singer.'
(really/very)

5. When giving orders or requests but showing a little impatience

- '**Just** finish the task as quickly as you can'
(do it now!)

Still

1. Describe something that will happen in the near future. (in the negative).

- 'I've been waiting for 20 minutes, but he **still** hasn't arrived!'
(Still waiting)

2. Describe that an action is continuing and hasn't finished yet.

- 'He is **still** washing his car.'
(should be finished by now)

3. Express something that is a habit that has not changed, even if maybe it should have.

- 'He is 25 now, but he **still** lives with his mum.'
(Should be living alone by now)

Yet

1. Describe something that we expect to happen soon. (negative sentences).

- 'I've been waiting for 20 minutes, but he hasn't arrived yet!'
(Still waiting)

2. To express a meaning similar to 'nonetheless' or 'but'.

- 'He has retired, **yet** he still continues to work.'



 Activity

Complete the sentences below using the words in the box.

already	just	still	yet
----------------	-------------	--------------	------------

1. I really love her music. Her songs are _____ amazing!
2. Have you called your boss _____? He is waiting to hear your decision.
3. He's been outside for hours and he _____ isn't finished. What is he doing?
4. I can't meet you tonight I'm afraid. I _____ have plans.
5. Did you read the new J.K. Rowling novel? I _____ haven't had time to read it.
6. _____ keep the noise down will you? I'm trying to study in here!
7. The plane arrived 20 minutes ago, but he _____ hasn't come out of the gate.
8. Don't worry about making me dinner. I have _____ eaten.
9. The boy knows he can't win, _____ he won't give up.
10. Did you say you wanted to find someone to fix your computer. I know _____ the man for the job!

Answers:

1. just
2. yet
3. still
4. already
5. still
6. just
7. still
8. already
9. yet
10. just



C1 (ADVANCED) LEVEL OF ENGLISH: ALL THE GRAMMAR AND VOCABULARY POINTS YOU MUST LEARN

This ebook outlines the necessary skills you will need to master to reach the C1 level in English. Use this ebook as a guide to help determine your current skill level and identify areas of weakness!

WHAT ARE THE CEFR LEVELS OF ENGLISH?



THE A1 ENGLISH LEVEL

The A1 level of English is the beginner level of language proficiency. Learners at this level can use simple phrases and expressions to communicate about everyday situations. They can introduce themselves, ask and answer basic questions and can have simple conversations.

THE A2 ENGLISH LEVEL



The A2 level of English relates to learners who can communicate in everyday situations using elementary vocabulary and commonly-used expressions. Learners at this level can understand sentences related to personal and family information, shopping, employment, etc. They can communicate in simple tasks and describe aspects of their past and immediate needs.



THE B1 ENGLISH LEVEL

The B1 level of English is for independent users who can understand clear texts about familiar topics in work, study or leisure contexts. Learners at this level can handle most situations when travelling to areas where English is used. They can produce simple and coherent texts about topics they know about or are personally interested in. They can describe experiences, events, wishes and aspirations, as well as explain plans and briefly justify opinions.



THE B2 ENGLISH LEVEL



The B2 level of English is for proficient users who can comprehend complex texts on concrete and abstract topics, including detailed discussions in their area of speciality. Learners at this level can interact fluently and spontaneously with native speakers without difficulty for either party. They can produce clear and detailed texts on a wide range of subjects and explain viewpoints on topical issues by providing the advantages and disadvantages of various options.



THE C1 ENGLISH LEVEL

The C1 level of English is for advanced users who can comprehend a wide range of demanding and lengthy texts, including implicit meanings. Learners at this level can express themselves fluently and spontaneously without hesitation. Learners can utilise language with versatility and effectiveness across various social, academic and professional settings. They can generate coherent, well-organised and elaborate texts on diverse topics, displaying accurate use of organisational structures, connectors and elements that ensure cohesion.

THE C2 ENGLISH LEVEL



The C2 level of English is the highest level of proficiency recognised by the CEFRL. At this level, learners can effortlessly comprehend anything they read or hear and are capable of summarising information and arguments from multiple sources, both spoken and written, and presenting them coherently and concisely. They can express themselves spontaneously, fluently and precisely, even in complex situations where finer shades of meaning must be discerned.



C1 ENGLISH QUICK CHECKLIST

<u>Grammar Topics</u>	✗	✓
Proficiency using the <u>past</u> , <u>present</u> and <u>future</u> tenses and their advanced uses		
Comfortable with using <u>modal verbs</u> and some of their advanced structures		
Able to use <u>conditionals</u> , <u>mixed conditionals</u> and <u>higher-level variations</u>		
Mastery of the <u>passive voice</u> including the infinitive and '-ing' forms		
A strong understanding of <u>negative inversion</u> and how to use it effectively		
Correct usage of <u>hedging</u> and <u>boosting</u> in speaking and writing		
Can use and understand <u>phrasal verbs</u> and their multiple meanings in various contexts		
Able to form complex and varied sentence structures using <u>coordinating</u> , <u>correlative</u> and <u>subordinating conjunctions</u> and <u>connectors</u>		
Familiar with: • non-finite clauses • advanced comparative structures • advanced discourse markers • fixed expressions		

<u>Vocabulary Topics</u>	✗	✓
Knowledge of a wide range of vocabulary topics (<i>approx. 8,000 words</i>)		
Understanding of <u>word families</u> including <u>roots</u> , <u>prefixes</u> and <u>suffixes</u>		
Familiar with <u>inclusive vocabulary</u> and the <u>evolution</u> of the English language		
A grasp on the different functions of the English language, like <u>play on words</u> , <u>double entendre</u> and <u>innuendos</u>		
Confident when presenting <u>arguments</u> and <u>debating</u>		
Able to recognise <u>passive-aggressive language</u>		



A BREAKDOWN OF C1 ENGLISH

The C1 level is fluency with a deep understanding of the nuances of the language.

You should be able to express yourself with phrases native speakers use and be able to do it naturally, which means saying things like:

I can't wait to put my own stamp on this place

instead of

I can't wait to redecorate.

C1 also demands a massively increased vocabulary: you should know around 8,000 words — that's twice as many as the 4,000 you need to know at B2, and you should be able to express yourself spontaneously without searching for words. You should also be able to understand subtle jokes in English at C1 level.

C1 is a wonderful level of English to reach. At this level, you should feel confident in almost any situation, and you should really enjoy speaking the language. These are two things that many of my students strive for. C1 is less about learning entirely new grammatical structures as you should already have learnt most of them at B2 and below; rather, it is about learning grammatical nuances, adding to your repertoire of phrases and building your instincts for English grammar.

This eBook will walk you through the grammar and vocabulary you need to know to achieve the C1 level.



GRAMMAR - MAIN POINTS TO CONSIDER

1 The Tenses

If you feel ready to study at C1 level in English, you should already have a strong foundation in the English tenses. However, a C1 course will provide you with revision of the **past**, **present** and **future** tenses, with a focus on their **advanced uses**.

For example, you should know how to use the Future Perfect Tense to make assumptions about the present, like

I'm sure my husband will have noticed that I used all the milk this morning.

If you're studying at C1, you should also learn how to talk about the future using some advanced structures, like '**to be set to**' and '**to be on the verge of**' and when it's appropriate to use these structures.

2 Modals

At the C1 level, you should be comfortable with using **modal verbs** and know some advanced structures for speculation and deduction. You'll be able to use modal verbs with adverbs that collocate with them, like

They could conceivably have driven all that way in one night, but it's unlikely.

You'll also know how to use structures such as '**the odds are**' and '**I dare say**'

I dare say I'll have to brush up on my grammar before I do a new course.

3 Conditionals

At C1 level, you should already be familiar with the **basic conditionals** and even with **mixed conditionals**.

When you're at C1, you should learn about a range of words and phrases to



replace 'if' and to take your conditionals to a more advanced level.

For example,

But for a wonderful trip to Spain when I was younger, I would never have decided to learn the language.

or

Given that I'd like to achieve C1 level in English, I'm going to have to study harder.

4 The Passive Voice

Again, if you've reached C1, you should be well-versed in how to use the **passive voice**.

At C1, there'll be a focus on using the passive infinitive and passive -ing forms, in sentences like

Lucy recalled having been taught about the passive voice at some point in the past.

And you'll need to learn about the subtle differences between phrases like,

There's nothing to do.

and

There's nothing to be done.

5 Negative Inversion

You also need to have a strong understanding of how to use **negative inversion** to add emphasis and variation to your writing and speaking.

Inversion is widely used in literary contexts, so understanding this structure can help you understand and analyse a wide range of texts more effectively, particularly those with complex or literary styles.



Never have I seen such a beautiful sunset.

Such was the commotion that I could barely hear myself think.

6 Hedging and Boosting

Those at a C1 level should be familiar with **hedging** and **boosting** when writing and speaking.

Hedging is a linguistic strategy that allows speakers to soften or downplay the force of their statements, often by using hedging verbs like '**to seem**', the passive voice, and adverbs like '**presumably**'.

It seems like this might be a good solution.

Boosting, on the other hand, involves using language to increase the force or impact of a statement, often by using adverbs like '**undeniably**' and strong verbs like '**to prove**'.

This has been proven to be the best solution to our problem.

7 Phrasal Verbs with Multiple Meanings

Another important aspect of achieving a C1 level of English is understanding the various meanings of a number of **phrasal verbs**.

Depending on the context, phrasal verbs can take on different meanings. To effectively communicate and understand advanced conversations, you will need proficiency in using phrasal verbs.

Here's a quick example using the phrasal verb '**set up**':

set up (a time for a meeting):

Let's set up a meeting for next week.

set up (people on a date):

My friend set me up with her cousin.



set up (the living room for a playdate):

I need to set up the living room for the kids.

8 Conjunctions and Connectors

Some of the most important grammatical tools C1 level students need to master are the use of **coordinating**, **correlative** and **subordinating conjunctions** and **connectors** because they enable you to form more complex and varied sentence structures, enhancing your ability to express ideas and arguments.

These tools also help to establish logical connections between ideas, making written and spoken communication more coherent, persuasive and fluid overall.

These should have been learnt at the B1/B2 level, but a demonstrated level of proficiency is necessary at the C1 level.

coordinating conjunctions:

She loves peanuts, but she's allergic to them.

correlative conjunctions:

Neither of us wanted to go to the concert, nor did we have the money to buy tickets.

subordinating conjunctions:

While I was walking my dog, I saw a beautiful sunset.

connectors:

He missed his flight; therefore, he had to stay at a hotel overnight.

There are many more structures, words and phrases you should know at C1 level, like how to use **non-finite clauses**, **advanced comparative structures**, like, "***It was so great a film that I had to see it twice,***" and **advanced discourse markers** and **fixed expressions** that you can use in writing and speech.



VOCABULARY - KEY FOCUS POINTS

When it comes to vocabulary, you should be able to express yourself fluently and spontaneously on a wide range of topics and be able to understand complex written and spoken texts.

You'll need to know a **wide range of vocabulary** on the topics of your lifestyle and well-being, nutrition and how it affects you, housing and urban versus rural life, and how people's different personalities mean you gel with someone and not someone else.

At C1, you'll also have to be comfortable with language connected to work and business, including the hot-button topics of remote working, burnout and resignation, freelancing and changing careers.

1 Word Formation

Understanding **word families** is an important skill that helps expand your vocabulary through **roots**, **prefixes** and **suffixes**, which help deduce the meaning of unfamiliar words. You'll also need to use them correctly in context, as well as have the skill to recognise and use words in different forms, such as noun, verb, adjective or adverb.

For example:

- **decide** (verb)
- **decision** (noun) - **indecision** (negative noun)
- **decisive** (adjective) - **indecisive** (negative adjective)

2 Paraphrasing

Paraphrasing is another important skill to develop for achieving a C1 level of English because it allows you to express ideas in your own words while maintaining the meaning and intent of the original text.

This skill is particularly valuable in academic and professional contexts, where accurately conveying information and avoiding plagiarism is essential.



Here is a very quick example of paraphrasing:

The company is experiencing financial difficulties

to

The company is struggling financially.

3 Inclusive and Evolving Language

Two commonly overlooked aspects of achieving higher levels of English are understanding **inclusive language** and how **language evolves**.

Inclusive language is the use of language that avoids gender, racial or other biases and promotes equality and respect for all. As language continues to evolve, learners need to be aware of how language can both include and exclude different groups of people.

At the C1 level, you should be able to effectively communicate with diverse audiences and contribute to a more equitable society by using inclusive language and recognising how language changes over time.

So that's things like saying **chairperson** instead of defaulting to **chairman** and using **they** as a **singular pronoun**.

4 Humour

Understanding the different functions of the English language, like **play on words**, **double entendre** and **innuendos**, is essential for achieving a C1 level of English fluency.

These language nuances add humour and depth to communication, allowing for more engaging and diversified expression.

Like in these sentences:



play on words:

Why do we tell actors to "break a leg"? Because every play has a cast.

double entendre:

I told my wife she was drawing her eyebrows too high. She looked surprised.

innuendo:

I can't believe he's still working there after what happened.

At C1, you should also be confident when **presenting arguments** and **debating**, and you should be able to recognise **passive-aggressive language** in others.

Example:

Were you able to get the report finished? No? That's fine — I'll just do it myself.

To reach C1, you'll need to do extensive **reading** and **listening practice** with texts that contain real-life English and get familiar with understanding the language of both formal and informal texts.

And it's not just about receptive skills: you'll also need to hone your productive skills, so a C1 course involves lots of output, too.

If you master all of that, you'll be well on your way to being able to say that you've achieved C1 or an advanced level of English.

I cover all of that and a lot more in my new C1 Programme. Take a look through the curriculum on the next page. Here we dive deeper into grammar, vocabulary and pronunciation.



How to Pronounce Positive Contractions

It's time to learn a bit more about contractions. This is a lesson I'm sure you'll love! Contractions are a big part of speaking naturally and fluently. Native English speakers use them constantly. This lesson will teach you how to pronounce the most common positive contractions properly.

Contractions in Review

Contractions are formed when we take two short words and combine them into one. We often use verbs, auxiliaries and modals combined with a pronoun to form contractions.

The most common contractions are formed with:

am, is, are, had, has, would, and will.

For example:

I + will = I'll

Notice that we have to use an apostrophe to show that we have taken out a few letters to make the contraction.

CONTRACTIONS WITH BE VERBS

Uncontracted	Contracted	Pronunciation	Example
I am	I'm	/aɪm/	<u>I'm</u> sorry <u>I'm</u> late. There is so much traffic today!
He is	He's	/hi:z/ /his/ /ɪz/	<u>He's</u> at the store now, but he'll be back soon.
She is	She's	/ʃi:z/ /ʃɪz/	<u>She's</u> the smartest in the group!
It is	It's	/ɪts/	<u>It's</u> not supposed to go in the cupboard; it goes in the refrigerator.



You are	You're	/jʊə(r)/ /jɔː(r)/	<u>You're</u> right about that!
We are	We're	/wɪə(r)/	Alright, <u>we're</u> off to the cinema. See you in a few hours.
They are	They're	/ðeə(r)/	<u>They're</u> still here. Do you want me to get them for you?

CONTRACTIONS WITH HAS, HAVE, HAD

Has, have and had can be used to make contractions, but only when used as **auxiliary verbs**.

 **Auxiliary:**
I had just heard the news when you called me.

Main Verb:
I had a cup of coffee this morning.


We **cannot** use has, have or had as a contraction if it's the **main verb** in a sentence.

Uncontracted	Contracted	Pronunciation	Example
She has	She's	/ʃiːz/ /ʃɪz/	<u>She's</u> been working late most nights.
He has	He's	/hiːz/ /hɪz/	<u>He's</u> got a meeting at 10.
It has	It's	/ɪts/	<u>It's</u> been sitting out all night.

SHE IS OR SHE HAS?

A trick to figuring out if the contraction represents "is" or "has" is to see how the sentence is conjugated. If you see a past participle (been, seen, eaten) after the contraction, the **'s** represents **"has"**.

Examples:

He has
 He's been here for 20 minutes.
 He's in your office.
 He is

Uncontracted	Contracted	Pronunciation	Example
I have	I've	/aɪv/	<u>I've</u> been here all day!
You have	You've	/ju:v/	<u>You've</u> come all this way just to break up with me?
We have	We've	/wi:v/ /wiv/	<u>We've</u> taken the dog to the vet.

Uncontracted	Contracted	Pronunciation	Example
I had	I'd	/aɪd/	<u>I'd</u> been studying English for three years before moving to Leeds.
You had	You'd	/juːd/	You would have passed if <u>you'd</u> studied.
She had	She'd	/ʃiːd/	<u>She'd</u> been sleeping all day when he called her.
He had	He'd	/hiːd/	<u>He'd</u> left before us but was still late.
We had	We'd	/wiːd/ /wid/	<u>We'd</u> seen him around the office, but we didn't know he was the new boss.
They had	They'd	/ðeɪd/	<u>They'd</u> eaten before coming over.

CONTRACTIONS WITH WOULD

Uncontracted	Contracted	Pronunciation	Example
I would	I'd	/aɪd/	<u>I'd</u> like to visit London.
You would	You'd	/juːd/	<u>You'd</u> look good in this dress.
He would	He'd	/hiːd/	<u>He'd</u> love to spend time with his family.
She would	She'd	/ʃiːd/	<u>She'd</u> like to go on holiday.
It would	It'd	/ɪtəd/	<u>It'd</u> be great to see you when you're back!



We would	We'd	/wi:d/ /wid/	<u>We'd</u> love to come to your wedding.
They would	They'd	/ðeɪd/	<u>They'd</u> take the train, but the tickets are too expensive.

HAD OR WOULD?

Once again, we have some very familiar pronunciations. So how do we know if the contractions represent "had" or "would"?

Here are some tips to help you!

Would	Had
Would is followed by an infinitive: She would go... = She'd go... I would love... = I'd love...	A past participle follows had: I'd eaten... He'd gotten...
The present perfect tense follows would: They'd have slept... I'd have given...	

CONTRACTIONS WITH WILL

Uncontracted	Contracted	Pronunciation	Example
I will	I'll	/aɪl/	<u>I'll</u> come round later today.
You will	You'll	/ju:l/	I am a great cook, <u>you'll</u> see!
He will	He'll	/hi:l/	<u>He'll</u> put it on his credit card.



She will	She'll	/ʃi:l/	<u>She'll</u> sleep on the sofa.
It will	It'll	/ɪtl/	<u>It'll</u> need some food and water in the morning.
We will	We'll	/wi:l/ /wil/	<u>We'll</u> see you next week.
They will	They'll	/ðeɪl/	<u>They'll</u> move your luggage for you.

OTHER COMMON CONTRACTIONS

Uncontracted	Contracted	Pronunciation	Example
Should have	should've	/ʃədəv/	We <u>should've</u> left much earlier!
Would have	would've	/wʊdəv/	She <u>would've</u> been so angry!
Could have	could've	/kədəv/	They <u>could've</u> come.
Want to	wanna	/ˈwɒnə/	I <u>wanna</u> go to yoga in the morning.
Going to	gonna	/ˈɡənə/	I'm <u>gonna</u> finish this project.





Activity

Choose the correct answer for each question.

1) /'ɪtl/ be easier to scoop if you leave it on the counter for a few minutes.

- a. It shall
- b. It will
- c. It is

2) I can't believe /ju:v/ just gotten in! Come and have a rest.

- a. they've
- b. I've
- c. you've

3) /hi:z/ been up all night waiting for the rain to stop.

- a. He's
- b. He is
- c. Hes

4) I can't believe I did that; /aɪm/ so sorry!

- a. I's
- b. I'm
- c. Im

Choose the contraction that best completes each sentence.

5) We are _____ go to the mall in an hour if you'd like to join.

- a. going to
- b. gonna'
- c. gonna

6) _____ in the middle of something right now; can I take a message?

- a. She's
- b. She'd
- c. She'll

7) _____ look for a place to eat after we check in.

- a. Will
- b. We'll
- c. Well

8) _____ sitting on the bed again. I thought you trained your cats not to do that?

- a. Theyre
- b. They'd
- c. They're

Answers:

1) b 2) c 3) a 4) b 5) c 6) a 7) b 8) c

